



REVIEWED:

BMW i8

IT COMES FROM
THE FUTURE.

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You would not be blamed for being excited if you happened to spot a BMW i8 on road. BMW's poster boy for the future is one of the rarest cars that you would spot on Indian roads, for multiple reasons. The BMW i8 is not the most luxurious or spacious car for its price point. It has a ground clearance of 113mm, which is so low that it will scrape against most speed breakers on our roads. You would also need to charge it regularly to make the most of its hybrid powertrain, but looking at the lack of easily accessible charging points in India (we found none in five days), it is rather inconvenient. However, the i8 is one for the future – a mighty good one at that, going by what it has on show.

Practicality is not its forte, and to expect practical elements like soaring mileage and loads of comfortable seating space would be wrong. The BMW i8 is more of a proof-of-concept in production, giving a glimpse at

BMW's futuristic performance car design, an eco-friendly powertrain that is also efficient and still powerful, and a bunch of technologies that are actually applicable and helpful on the road. As a result, the term 'practicality' here takes on a different meaning - for a car that is definitely ahead of its time, the BMW i8 delivers more than impressive mileage of up to 14kmpl, and if you've ever fancied driving something that resembles the Batmobile in ways, the BMW i8 is about the closest you can practically get to your dream, in India.

Driving the i8 is a 1.5-litre, 3-cylinder petrol engine. This rather tiny en-

gine delivers a staggering 231bhp and 320Nm torque, which by themselves are insanely high numbers. The small engine has been tuned to deliver more power than the 2-litre, turbocharged petrol mill that powers the Skoda Octavia RS - a full-size performance sedan. But, the i8's powertrain is further enhanced by an electric motor to the front that produces 131bhp and 250Nm torque by itself, mated to BMW's high performance Lithium ion battery. This leads to total power and torque figures of 362bhp and 570Nm torque. These figures may not be mighty by supercar standards, but on standalone terms, this engine-and-motor combination makes the BMW i8 really fast.

You can put the car on eDrive mode, which shifts the car to electric power only. In this mode, you can drive only in Eco Pro and Comfort modes, and for up to 60km. Beyond this, or if you push too hard or switch to Sport mode, the car disengages the electric-only powertrain and switches to the engine, with the electric motor assisting the

